AB Power Meter Monitor 1.6.3 - Windows test kit

William W. Wallace, NRAO/GBO

2026-10-27

AB Power Meter Monitor 1.6.3 — Windows test kit

Everything needed to test the monitor on a Windows 10/11 PC (first run on **txrx03**, Windows 11 26H2, i9, 2026-10-26). No real meters are needed: a built-in emulator serves the 11 meter pages for two meters on `127.0.0.2` and `127.0.0.3`. Nothing outside the kit folder is changed; delete the folder to remove everything.

New in 1.6.3 / kit 1.1.0 (from the txrx03 results)

Found on txrx03	Fix
GUI closed with exit code `-1066598273` (0xC06D007F) on the first plot	NumPy's matrix library, Intel oneMKL 2026.1.0, crashed inside `np.dot` on that CPU. The kit now installs **OpenBLAS** (`libblas=*=*openblas`), confirmed on txrx03: 80 polls, every output written, no warning.
OpenBLAS showed ~3 GB of commit charge (2,971 MB)	The monitor sets `OPENBLAS_NUM_THREADS=1` before NumPy loads (measured 18 MB). A value you set yourself is kept.
First poll in step 5 refused by the emulator	Steps 4 and 5 now wait until the emulator answers (`wait_for_port.py`, max 30 s).
An offline meter cost ~67 s and 44 warnings per poll	Its remaining pages are skipped once it refuses the connection (`SKIP_PAGES_WHEN_UNREACHABLE`).
"final writes: up to date" when no meter ever answered	Now "no data received".

Already have the 1.6.2 kit environment? Re-running step 1 into a new folder is the clean way. To switch an existing `env\` in place instead (PowerShell or cmd, kit folder): `mamba install -y -p .\env -c conda-forge --override-channels "libblas=*=*openblas"`

PowerShell or cmd

Double-clicking the `.bat` files is simplest. From a terminal:

	PowerShell	cmd
Run a step	`.\4_gui_with_emulator.bat`	`4_gui_with_emulator.bat`
Kit Python	`.\env\python.exe …`	`env\python.exe …`
Change folder	`cd C:\path`	`cd /d C:\path`
Start in a new window	`Start-Process .\env\python.exe -ArgumentList …`	`start "" env\python.exe …`

No conda environment needs to be active: the kit always runs its own `env\python.exe`. Run `mamba deactivate` until the prompt shows no `(base)` / `(py3p12)` if in doubt.

Your own environments (e.g. `py3p12`)

The monitor also runs in your own conda environment. If its NumPy uses oneMKL 2026.1.0 the GUI can crash the same way; switch it with `mamba install -n py3p12 -c conda-forge "libblas=*=*openblas"`. (`py3p12` currently has MKL 2026.2.0, which works on txrx03 but has been marked *broken* on conda-forge, so a future update may replace it.)

What it checks

Area	How
RAM flush gives memory back to **Windows** (1.6.1)	`windows_memory_check.py` reads the working set and commit charge with `GetProcessMemoryInfo`; step 3 lets you watch it in Task Manager
Output files held open by **Excel** (1.6.2)	`test_windows_file_locks.py` locks the CSV, Markdown, XLSX and FITS files the way Excel does (`CreateFileW`, read-share only)
Ctrl+Break stops the headless monitor and the exporter cleanly (1.6.2 / 0.1.1)	headless soak and exporter test send `CTRL_BREAK_EVENT`
No row lost or written twice, in every output, across flushes	offline suite + headless soak (CSV = Markdown = .vszh5 = XLSX = FITS row counts)
No leak over time	GUI soak (widgets, RSS, handles, GDI/USER objects) and headless soak (working set, handles, threads)
Python 3.12 on Windows	every suite, with this project's DeprecationWarnings as errors

Before you start

1. **Unblock the 7z** before extracting: right-click it → *Properties* → tick *Unblock* → *OK*. (Otherwise Windows asks before every `.bat`.)
2. **Use a short path without spaces**, e.g. `C:\ABTest` or the ready copy in `C:\Users\wwallace\Claude\AB_Monitor_1.6.3_`. Conda environments break on paths with spaces; the setup refuses them.
3. Have **Miniforge** (mamba) installed — the setup also finds conda, micromamba, Miniconda or Anaconda. Without any of them it falls back to python.org Python 3.12 (`py -3.12`) with pip.
4. About **3 GB** free disk and an internet connection for step 1.

Steps

Step	Double-click	Time	What happens
1	`1_setup_environment.bat`	5–10 min	creates `env\` (Python 3.12.15 and the exact package versions tested); asks whether to add `env_veusz\` (Veusz 4.2.1, for the real-Veusz checks and "Open in Veusz") — answer **Y** unless Veusz is installed
2	`2_run_all_tests.bat`	~20 min	all eight suites; writes `results\<computer>_<time>\` and **`results\AB_TestResults_<computer>_<time>.zip`**. `2_run_all_tests.bat --quick` takes ~8 min
3	`3_task_manager_check.bat`	~3 min	six flush runs, each pausing 20 s so you can watch Task Manager
4	`4_gui_with_emulator.bat`	~10 min	the real GUI against the emulator — follow the checklist below

Step	Double-click	Time	What happens
5	`5_headless_with_emulator.bat`	~3 min	headless run with a visible log; stop it with **Ctrl+C** or **Ctrl+Break**

Longer soak (optional, e.g. over lunch): `2_run_all_tests.bat --only headless_soak --soak-minutes 60`

Step 3 — what to look for

Task Manager → *Details* → right-click a column header → *Select columns* → tick **Working set (memory)** and **Commit size**. Each run prints its PID. After the flush of a `full` run the working set W should fall back close to where it started:

$$W_{\text{after flush}} \leq W_{\text{idle}} + 0.3\,(W_{\text{filled}} - W_{\text{idle}})$$

`gc_only` is how 1.6.0 behaved on Windows (rows dropped, memory kept); `heap_only` releases heap memory without trimming the working set; `full` is the default since 1.6.1. Commit size falls by whatever the heaps could decommit; it is reported, not judged.

Step 4 — GUI checklist

The GUI writes to `gui_output\`. Tick the outputs you want (CSV at least) and press **Start Auto**.

- ☐ Window opens; *View* menu switches light/dark theme; previews update every 2 s.
- ☐ Status line shows `Store … | RSS … MB (commit … MB) | system RAM … %`.
- ☐ **Flush RAM Now** → log line `OS release [heap_optimize ok, working_set_trim ok]; RSS a -> b MB, commit c -> d MB`, and the python.exe working set in Task Manager drops.
- ☐ Open `gui_output\csv\ABMeter_127_0_0_2_Real_Time_Power_Table.csv` **in Excel** while polling → exactly **one** warning "is open in another program", no errors, polling continues.
- ☐ With the CSV still open in Excel, press **Save Now** → a `…_rescue.csv` file appears next to it.
- ☐ Close Excel → within one poll the rescue file disappears and the CSV continues without gaps or duplicates (rows in time order).
- ☐ **Open in Veusz** (needs `env_veusz` or an installed Veusz) opens `ABMeter_127_0_0_2.vszh5`; it keeps growing while polling (reload in Veusz).
- ☐ Close the window while polling → it waits for the final writes, then closes.

Step 5 — headless stop

Press **Ctrl+Break** (or Ctrl+C) in the monitor window: the log must end with `Final writes done` and the exit code must be 0. Answer **N** if cmd asks "Terminate batch job (Y/N)?". Many laptops have no Break key — Ctrl+C does the same here; Ctrl+Break matters for supervisors that send `CTRL_BREAK_EVENT`.

What to send back

1. `results\AB_TestResults_<computer>_<time>.zip` (from step 2 — the main one).
2. `results\task_manager_check.json` (step 3) and, if you like, a Task Manager screenshot.
3. Which GUI checklist items passed or failed, and anything odd.

Troubleshooting

Symptom	Fix
"Windows protected your PC" / security warning per `.bat`	unblock the 7z (see *Before you start*) and extract again
Setup: "path contains a space"	move the kit to e.g. `C:\ABTest`

Symptom	Fix
Setup: neither mamba/conda nor Python 3.12 found	install Miniforge (https://github.com/conda-forge/miniforge), then run step 1 again
`system.json` shows `loopback_127_0_0_2: false`	the emulator cannot use 127.0.0.2; report it — the tests need it
A firewall prompt	should not appear (everything binds to 127.0.0.x); allowing “private networks” is harmless
Tests slow	antivirus scanning the many small writes; normal, the time limits allow for it
Port 18080 in use (steps 4–5)	edit the two `.bat` files: change both `18080` to another free port
Rebuild the environment	delete `env\` (and `env_veusz\`), run step 1 again

Verified

- **txrx03** (Windows 11 26H2, i9, 32 GB), 1.6.2 kit, 2026-10-26: 7 of 8 suites passed. Memory flush: working set 298 → 4 MiB. Headless soak: 591 polls = 591 rows in CSV, Markdown, .vszh5, XLSX and FITS, Ctrl+Break stop clean. The GUI suite failed with the MKL crash above; with OpenBLAS the GUI ran 80 polls writing every output.

Before the first shipment (2026-10-26)

- Linux, Python 3.12.3: all eight suites pass (`run_all_tests.py --quick`).
- Windows build of Python 3.12.15 (same package versions as `environment-windows-test.txt`) under Wine 9.0: setup script, memory release, file locks (real `CreateFileW` locks), memory check and the GUI soak pass. Not checkable under Wine, so checked for the first time on your PC: the real Veusz render, the Ctrl+Break stop, and the Task Manager drop itself.

Files

File	Purpose
`1_` … `5_*.bat`	the steps above
`_env.bat`	shared settings for the steps (finds `env\python.exe`; PATH unchanged)
`environment-windows-test.txt`	exact conda-forge versions for `env\`
`environment-veusz.txt`	Veusz 4.2.1 for `env_veusz\`
`app\`	the monitor 1.6.3, exporter 0.1.1, writer, tests, docs
`app\tests\run_all_tests.py`	the runner behind step 2 (options: `--quick`, `--only`, `--skip`, `--soak-minutes`, `--gui-seconds`, `--veusz-exe`)